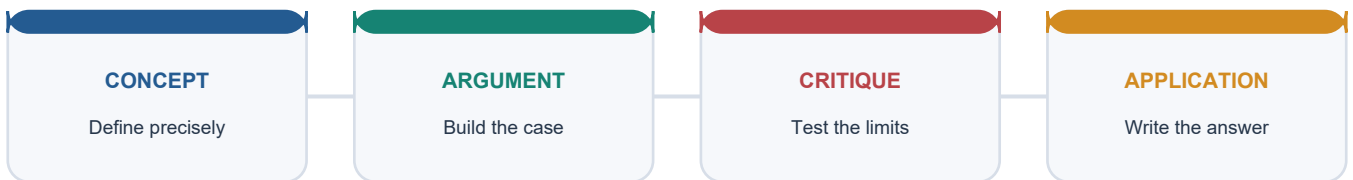


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Ministries, Departments and Central Secretariat - Exact Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Ministries, Departments and Central Secretariat - Solved Practice Workbook 4

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 4

MCQ 1	4
MCQ 2	4
MCQ 3	5
MCQ 4	5
MCQ 5	5
MCQ 6	6
MCQ 7	6
MCQ 8	7
MCQ 9	7
MCQ 10	8
MCQ 11	8
MCQ 12	8
MCQ 13	9
MCQ 14	9
MCQ 15	10
MCQ 16	10
MCQ 17	11
MCQ 18	11
MCQ 19	11
MCQ 20	12
MCQ 21	12
MCQ 22	13
MCQ 23	13
MCQ 24	13
MCQ 25	14
MCQ 26	14
MCQ 27	15

MCQ 28	15
MCQ 29	15
MCQ 30	16
MCQ 31	16
MCQ 32	17
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	17
VERIFIED DIRECT PYQ 1 - 2025 PRELIMS GS-I, SET A Q57 - OBJECTIVE	17
VERIFIED SUPPORTING PYQ 2 - 2020 GS-II Q7 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS	18
VERIFIED SUPPORTING PYQ 3 - 2024 GS-II Q3 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS	18
ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS	19
ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS	19
ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS, 250 WORDS	20
ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS, 250 WORDS	20
ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS, 250 WORDS	21
ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS, 250 WORDS	21

Ministries, Departments and Central Secretariat - Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: Exactly 32 original MCQs before verified PYQs; keys rotate ABCD eight times; every option has a unique explanation; every MCQ has a unique trap; exactly six original Mains models follow the verified PYQs.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

Article 53 is best understood as A. vesting Union executive power formally in the President, exercisable according to the Constitution B. creating the Cabinet Secretariat as a constitutional office C. allocating all Union subjects among departments D. making every executive decision a personal presidential act

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 1 turns on the proposition that vesting Union executive power formally in the President, exercisable according to the Constitution. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 1 is that vesting Union executive power formally in the President, exercisable according to the Constitution. Option B instead asserts that creating the Cabinet Secretariat as a constitutional office, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 1 is that vesting Union executive power formally in the President, exercisable according to the Constitution. Option C instead asserts that allocating all Union subjects among departments, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 1 is that vesting Union executive power formally in the President, exercisable according to the Constitution. Option D instead asserts that making every executive decision a personal presidential act, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 1: Do not confuse formal vesting with personal administration.

MCQ 2

Article 73 principally concerns A. authentication of executive instruments B. the extent of Union executive power, broadly linked to Parliament's legislative field subject to federal limits C. the voting rights of ministers in Parliament D. the constitution of Cabinet Committees

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 2 is that the extent of Union executive power, broadly linked to Parliament's legislative field subject to federal limits. Option A instead asserts that authentication of executive instruments, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 2 turns on the proposition that the extent of Union executive power, broadly linked to Parliament's legislative field subject to federal limits. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 2 is that the extent of Union executive power, broadly linked to Parliament's legislative field subject to federal limits. Option C instead asserts that the voting rights of ministers in Parliament, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 2 is that the extent of Union executive power, broadly linked to Parliament's legislative field subject to federal limits. Option D instead asserts that the constitution of Cabinet Committees, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 2: Extent of power is different from form and transaction.

MCQ 3

Which combination is correct? A. Article 74-allocation among ministries; Article 75-authentication B. Article 74-ministerial voting; Article 75-treaty power C. Article 74-PM-led Council aids and advises; Article 75-collective responsibility to Lok Sabha D. Article 74-CAG audit; Article 75-judicial review

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 3 is that Article 74-PM-led Council aids and advises; Article 75-collective responsibility to Lok Sabha. Option A instead asserts that Article 74-allocation among ministries; Article 75-authentication, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 3 is that Article 74-PM-led Council aids and advises; Article 75-collective responsibility to Lok Sabha. Option B instead asserts that Article 74-ministerial voting; Article 75-treaty power, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 3 turns on the proposition that Article 74-PM-led Council aids and advises; Article 75-collective responsibility to Lok Sabha. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 3 is that Article 74-PM-led Council aids and advises; Article 75-collective responsibility to Lok Sabha. Option D instead asserts that Article 74-CAG audit; Article 75-judicial review, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 3: Aid and advice and collective responsibility are adjacent but distinct.

MCQ 4

Article 88 allows a Union Minister to A. vote in both Houses whether or not a member B. vote only in joint sittings C. participate only in the House of membership D. speak and participate in either House and committees, but vote only where a member

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 4 is that speak and participate in either House and committees, but vote only where a member. Option A instead asserts that vote in both Houses whether or not a member, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 4 is that speak and participate in either House and committees, but vote only where a member. Option B instead asserts that vote only in joint sittings, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 4 is that speak and participate in either House and committees, but vote only where a member. Option C instead asserts that participate only in the House of membership, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 4 turns on the proposition that speak and participate in either House and committees, but vote only where a member. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 4: Participation does not imply a cross-House vote.

MCQ 5

Under Article 77(1), executive action of the Government of India is A. expressed to be taken in the President's name B. necessarily signed personally by the President C. immune from judicial review after authentication D. valid even without substantive competence

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 5 turns on the proposition that expressed to be taken in the President's name. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 5 is that expressed to be taken in the President's name. Option B instead asserts that necessarily signed personally by the President, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 5 is that expressed to be taken in the President's name. Option C instead asserts that immune from judicial review after authentication, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 5 is that expressed to be taken in the President's name. Option D instead asserts that valid even without substantive competence, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 5: Formal expression is not personal authorship or immunity.

MCQ 6

The principal protection of proper authentication under Article 77(2) is that A. it cures violation of every statute B. validity cannot be questioned merely because the order was not personally made or executed by the President C. it creates the substantive source of power D. it removes the need for a competent authority

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 6 is that validity cannot be questioned merely because the order was not personally made or executed by the President. Option A instead asserts that it cures violation of every statute, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 6 turns on the proposition that validity cannot be questioned merely because the order was not personally made or executed by the President. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 6 is that validity cannot be questioned merely because the order was not personally made or executed by the President. Option C instead asserts that it creates the substantive source of power, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 6 is that validity cannot be questioned merely because the order was not personally made or executed by the President. Option D instead asserts that it removes the need for a competent authority, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 6: Authentication answers a formal objection, not every illegality.

MCQ 7

Article 77(3) is the source for rules concerning A. service recruitment and conditions exclusively B. constitutional amendment of ministries C. convenient transaction and allocation of Government of India business among ministers D. distribution of legislative fields between Union and States

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 7 is that convenient transaction and allocation of Government of India business among ministers. Option A instead asserts that service recruitment and conditions exclusively, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 7 is that convenient transaction and allocation of Government of India business among ministers. Option B instead asserts that constitutional amendment of ministries, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 7 turns on the proposition that convenient transaction and allocation of Government of India business among ministers. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 7 is that convenient transaction and allocation of Government of India business among ministers. Option D instead asserts that distribution of legislative fields between Union and States, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 7: Article 309 is the service-rule trap; Article 77(3) is business.

MCQ 8

Which statement about Article 78 is correct? A. It makes the PMO a constitutional body B. It authorises the PM to amend a parent Act C. It makes the Cabinet Secretary answerable to Rajya Sabha D. It requires the Prime Minister to communicate decisions/proposals and furnish information to the President

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 8 is that It requires the Prime Minister to communicate decisions/proposals and furnish information to the President. Option A instead asserts that It makes the PMO a constitutional body, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 8 is that It requires the Prime Minister to communicate decisions/proposals and furnish information to the President. Option B instead asserts that It authorises the PM to amend a parent Act, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 8 is that It requires the Prime Minister to communicate decisions/proposals and furnish information to the President. Option C instead asserts that It makes the Cabinet Secretary answerable to Rajya Sabha, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 8 turns on the proposition that It requires the Prime Minister to communicate decisions/proposals and furnish information to the President. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 8: Article 78 concerns the PM-President information relationship.

MCQ 9

The Allocation of Business Rules primarily answer A. which governmental unit owns a subject B. which court reviews an executive order C. how a Bill is passed in Parliament D. how civil servants are recruited

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 9 turns on the proposition that which governmental unit owns a subject. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 9 is that which governmental unit owns a subject. Option B instead asserts that which court reviews an executive order, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 9 is that which governmental unit owns a subject. Option C instead asserts that how a Bill is passed in Parliament, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 9 is that which governmental unit owns a subject. Option D instead asserts that how civil servants are recruited, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 9: Remember AoB as the address, not the travel route.

MCQ 10

Under the AoB Rules, the First Schedule principally identifies A. mandatory Finance consultations B. Ministries, Departments, Secretariats and Offices through which business is transacted C. Cabinet cases requiring approval D. constitutional bodies only

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 10 is that Ministries, Departments, Secretariats and Offices through which business is transacted. Option A instead asserts that mandatory Finance consultations, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 10 turns on the proposition that Ministries, Departments, Secretariats and Offices through which business is transacted. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 10 is that Ministries, Departments, Secretariats and Offices through which business is transacted. Option C instead asserts that Cabinet cases requiring approval, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 10 is that Ministries, Departments, Secretariats and Offices through which business is transacted. Option D instead asserts that constitutional bodies only, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 10: First Schedule unit-listing must not be exchanged with Second Schedule subjects.

MCQ 11

The Second Schedule to the AoB Rules principally A. lists ministerial oaths B. fixes Cabinet Committee composition C. distributes governmental subjects among departments D. creates statutory regulators

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 11 is that distributes governmental subjects among departments. Option A instead asserts that lists ministerial oaths, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 11 is that distributes governmental subjects among departments. Option B instead asserts that fixes Cabinet Committee composition, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 11 turns on the proposition that distributes governmental subjects among departments. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 11 is that distributes governmental subjects among departments. Option D instead asserts that creates statutory regulators, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 11: Subject distribution is administrative allocation, not statutory creation.

MCQ 12

A ministry reorganisation under business rules A. always requires Article 368 amendment B. automatically amends every statute C. can disregard an authority named in a parent Act D. ordinarily can rename/merge/split units, but cannot override statutory assignments

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 12 is that ordinarily can rename/merge/split units, but cannot override statutory assignments. Option A instead asserts that always requires Article 368 amendment, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 12 is that ordinarily can rename/merge/split units, but cannot override statutory assignments. Option B instead asserts that automatically amends every statute, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 12 is that ordinarily can rename/merge/split units, but cannot override statutory assignments. Option C instead asserts that can disregard an authority named in a parent Act, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 12 turns on the proposition that ordinarily can rename/merge/split units, but cannot override statutory assignments. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 12: Flexible organisation remains subordinate to legislation.

MCQ 13

Rule 3 of the ToB framework means ordinary departmental business is generally disposed of A. by or under directions of the Minister-in-charge, subject to consultation and higher-submission rules B. only by the Cabinet C. only by the President personally D. only by the Cabinet Secretary

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 13 turns on the proposition that by or under directions of the Minister-in-charge, subject to consultation and higher-submission rules. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 13 is that by or under directions of the Minister-in-charge, subject to consultation and higher-submission rules. Option B instead asserts that only by the Cabinet, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 13 is that by or under directions of the Minister-in-charge, subject to consultation and higher-submission rules. Option C instead asserts that only by the President personally, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 13 is that by or under directions of the Minister-in-charge, subject to consultation and higher-submission rules. Option D instead asserts that only by the Cabinet Secretary, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 13: Departmental disposal is the norm; apex submission is reserved.

MCQ 14

Where a case affects another department's allocated business, the sound ToB principle is A. the sponsoring department decides unilaterally B. affected departments concur or the disagreement follows an authorised collective resolution route C. the PMO automatically becomes the legal owner D. the file must be abandoned

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 14 is that affected departments concur or the disagreement follows an authorised collective resolution route. Option A instead asserts that the sponsoring department decides unilaterally, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 14 turns on the proposition that affected departments concur or the disagreement follows an authorised collective resolution route. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 14 is that affected departments concur or the disagreement follows an authorised collective resolution route. Option C instead asserts that the PMO automatically becomes the legal owner, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 14 is that affected departments concur or the disagreement follows an authorised collective resolution route. Option D instead asserts that the file must be abandoned, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 14: Consultation preserves other departments' jurisdiction; it does not transfer it.

MCQ 15

According to the Cabinet Secretariat's official summary, cases for Cabinet approval are indicated in the A. First Schedule to the AoB Rules B. Third Schedule to the ToB Rules C. Second Schedule to the ToB Rules D. Eighth Schedule to the Constitution

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 15 is that Second Schedule to the ToB Rules. Option A instead asserts that First Schedule to the AoB Rules, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 15 is that Second Schedule to the ToB Rules. Option B instead asserts that Third Schedule to the ToB Rules, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 15 turns on the proposition that Second Schedule to the ToB Rules. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 15 is that Second Schedule to the ToB Rules. Option D instead asserts that Eighth Schedule to the Constitution, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 15: Do not mix AoB schedules with ToB submission schedules.

MCQ 16

Rule 12 departure from the ToB Rules is most accurately described as A. a power of any Secretary to waive the Constitution B. a permanent repeal of consultation duties C. a power of a minister to amend a statute D. a PM power to permit or condone a departure to the necessary extent, still bounded by higher law

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 16 is that a PM power to permit or condone a departure to the necessary extent, still bounded by higher law. Option A instead asserts that a power of any Secretary to waive the Constitution, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 16 is that a PM power to permit or condone a departure to the necessary extent, still bounded by higher law. Option B instead asserts that a permanent repeal of consultation duties, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 16 is that a PM power to permit or condone a departure to the necessary extent, still bounded by higher law. Option C instead asserts that a power of a minister to amend a statute, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 16 turns on the proposition that a PM power to permit or condone a departure to the necessary extent, still bounded by higher law. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 16: Internal departure authority cannot waive the Constitution or statute.

MCQ 17

A portfolio is A. political charge assigned to a minister B. the basic clerical unit of a department C. always a separate ministry D. a statutory regulator

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 17 turns on the proposition that political charge assigned to a minister. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 17 is that political charge assigned to a minister. Option B instead asserts that the basic clerical unit of a department, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 17 is that political charge assigned to a minister. Option C instead asserts that always a separate ministry, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 17 is that political charge assigned to a minister. Option D instead asserts that a statutory regulator, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 17: Portfolio answers political charge, not administrative form.

MCQ 18

A department is best described as A. a committee of ministers B. an allocated subject-based administrative unit under a Secretary or equivalent C. the complete Council of Ministers D. a public sector company

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 18 is that an allocated subject-based administrative unit under a Secretary or equivalent. Option A instead asserts that a committee of ministers, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 18 turns on the proposition that an allocated subject-based administrative unit under a Secretary or equivalent. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 18 is that an allocated subject-based administrative unit under a Secretary or equivalent. Option C instead asserts that the complete Council of Ministers, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 18 is that an allocated subject-based administrative unit under a Secretary or equivalent. Option D instead asserts that a public sector company, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 18: Department and ministry can overlap in ordinary speech but are not analytically identical.

MCQ 19

The Central Secretariat is A. the same as the PMO B. one building with constitutional status C. the collective policy and coordination machinery of Union ministries/departments D. the field administration of every scheme

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 19 is that the collective policy and coordination machinery of Union ministries/departments. Option A instead asserts that the same as the PMO, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 19 is that the collective policy and coordination machinery of Union ministries/departments. Option B instead asserts that one building with constitutional status, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

- **C - Correct:** Question 19 turns on the proposition that the collective policy and coordination machinery of Union ministries/departments. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 19 is that the collective policy and coordination machinery of Union ministries/departments. Option D instead asserts that the field administration of every scheme, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 19: Central Secretariat is an aggregate machinery, not one central office.

MCQ 20

The Secretary's proper role is to A. replace the minister's political judgment B. send every file to the Cabinet C. avoid recording inconvenient advice D. provide frank lawful advice, organise due process and ensure delegated administration

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 20 is that provide frank lawful advice, organise due process and ensure delegated administration. Option A instead asserts that replace the minister's political judgment, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 20 is that provide frank lawful advice, organise due process and ensure delegated administration. Option B instead asserts that send every file to the Cabinet, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 20 is that provide frank lawful advice, organise due process and ensure delegated administration. Option C instead asserts that avoid recording inconvenient advice, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 20 turns on the proposition that provide frank lawful advice, organise due process and ensure delegated administration. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 20: Neutrality means professional advice and lawful implementation, not political veto.

MCQ 21

An attached office commonly performs A. detailed executive direction, technical support or specialised information functions B. collective Cabinet decision-making C. constitutional amendment D. independent parliamentary audit

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 21 turns on the proposition that detailed executive direction, technical support or specialised information functions. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 21 is that detailed executive direction, technical support or specialised information functions. Option B instead asserts that collective Cabinet decision-making, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 21 is that detailed executive direction, technical support or specialised information functions. Option C instead asserts that constitutional amendment, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 21 is that detailed executive direction, technical support or specialised information functions. Option D instead asserts that independent parliamentary audit, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 21: The label is administrative and actual powers still depend on the instrument.

MCQ 22

A subordinate office commonly focuses on A. Cabinet agenda preparation B. field execution, enforcement or service delivery C. allocating portfolios D. presidential reconsideration of advice

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 22 is that field execution, enforcement or service delivery. Option A instead asserts that Cabinet agenda preparation, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 22 turns on the proposition that field execution, enforcement or service delivery. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 22 is that field execution, enforcement or service delivery. Option C instead asserts that allocating portfolios, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 22 is that field execution, enforcement or service delivery. Option D instead asserts that presidential reconsideration of advice, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 22: Subordinate does not mean lawless or necessarily powerless.

MCQ 23

An autonomous body's autonomy is principally determined by A. a universal constitutional formula B. the personal preference of the minister C. its governing statute/instrument, finance and oversight arrangements D. absence of all audit

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 23 is that its governing statute/instrument, finance and oversight arrangements. Option A instead asserts that a universal constitutional formula, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 23 is that its governing statute/instrument, finance and oversight arrangements. Option B instead asserts that the personal preference of the minister, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 23 turns on the proposition that its governing statute/instrument, finance and oversight arrangements. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 23 is that its governing statute/instrument, finance and oversight arrangements. Option D instead asserts that absence of all audit, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 23: Grant support and autonomy can coexist.

MCQ 24

Ministerial stewardship over a statutory regulator A. permits oral reversal of any adjudicatory order B. abolishes statutory appeals C. makes the regulator a department D. must remain within the parent Act and cannot displace lawful decisional independence

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 24 is that must remain within the parent Act and cannot displace lawful decisional independence. Option A instead asserts that permits oral reversal of any adjudicatory order, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 24 is that must remain within the parent Act and cannot displace lawful decisional independence. Option B instead asserts that abolishes statutory appeals, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 24 is that must remain within the parent Act and cannot displace lawful decisional independence. Option C instead asserts that makes the regulator a department, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 24 turns on the proposition that must remain within the parent Act and cannot displace lawful decisional independence. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 24: Policy oversight is not case-specific appellate control.

MCQ 25

The Cabinet Secretariat officially A. administers the AoB/ToB Rules and supports Cabinet/Cabinet Committee processes B. functions as the whole Central Secretariat C. is headed politically by the Cabinet Secretary D. enacts parent statutes

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 25 turns on the proposition that administers the AoB/ToB Rules and supports Cabinet/Cabinet Committee processes. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 25 is that administers the AoB/ToB Rules and supports Cabinet/Cabinet Committee processes. Option B instead asserts that functions as the whole Central Secretariat, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 25 is that administers the AoB/ToB Rules and supports Cabinet/Cabinet Committee processes. Option C instead asserts that is headed politically by the Cabinet Secretary, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 25 is that administers the AoB/ToB Rules and supports Cabinet/Cabinet Committee processes. Option D instead asserts that enacts parent statutes, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 25: Cabinet Secretary is an official, not a Cabinet Minister.

MCQ 26

A Committee of Secretaries is A. a parliamentary committee B. an administrative coordination mechanism, generally chaired by the Cabinet Secretary C. a constitutional court D. a committee consisting only of ministers

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 26 is that an administrative coordination mechanism, generally chaired by the Cabinet Secretary. Option A instead asserts that a parliamentary committee, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 26 turns on the proposition that an administrative coordination mechanism, generally chaired by the Cabinet Secretary. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 26 is that an administrative coordination mechanism, generally chaired by the Cabinet Secretary. Option C instead asserts that a constitutional court, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 26 is that an administrative coordination mechanism, generally chaired by the Cabinet Secretary. Option D instead asserts that a committee consisting only of ministers, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 26: Committee of Secretaries and Cabinet Committee are close-option opposites.

MCQ 27

The PMO is best distinguished from the Cabinet Secretariat because the PMO A. is the custodian of all Cabinet papers by definition B. allocates legislative fields C. supports the Prime Minister directly, while the Cabinet Secretariat supports collective Cabinet procedure D. is a constitutional commission

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 27 is that supports the Prime Minister directly, while the Cabinet Secretariat supports collective Cabinet procedure. Option A instead asserts that is the custodian of all Cabinet papers by definition, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 27 is that supports the Prime Minister directly, while the Cabinet Secretariat supports collective Cabinet procedure. Option B instead asserts that allocates legislative fields, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 27 turns on the proposition that supports the Prime Minister directly, while the Cabinet Secretariat supports collective Cabinet procedure. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 27 is that supports the Prime Minister directly, while the Cabinet Secretariat supports collective Cabinet procedure. Option D instead asserts that is a constitutional commission, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 27: Both work around the PM but have different institutional clients.

MCQ 28

A Cabinet Committee is A. necessarily listed in the Constitution B. identical to a Committee of Secretaries C. a judicial body D. a selected-minister mechanism for specialised political consideration under business procedure

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 28 is that a selected-minister mechanism for specialised political consideration under business procedure. Option A instead asserts that necessarily listed in the Constitution, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 28 is that a selected-minister mechanism for specialised political consideration under business procedure. Option B instead asserts that identical to a Committee of Secretaries, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 28 is that a selected-minister mechanism for specialised political consideration under business procedure. Option C instead asserts that a judicial body, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 28 turns on the proposition that a selected-minister mechanism for specialised political consideration under business procedure. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 28: Names and number change; mechanism is the durable fact.

MCQ 29

In file procedure, noting is primarily A. recorded examination of facts, rules, issues, options and recommendation B. the final external communication alone C. an oral direction that need not enter the record D. the same as statutory publication

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Correct:** Question 29 turns on the proposition that recorded examination of facts, rules, issues, options and recommendation. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 29 is that recorded examination of facts, rules, issues, options and recommendation. Option B instead asserts that the final external communication alone, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 29 is that recorded examination of facts, rules, issues, options and recommendation. Option C instead asserts that an oral direction that need not enter the record, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 29 is that recorded examination of facts, rules, issues, options and recommendation. Option D instead asserts that the same as statutory publication, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 29: Noting and drafting perform different stages.

MCQ 30

e-Office reform A. creates legal competence by digitisation B. changes the processing medium and traceability, not the source of authority C. removes record-retention duties D. eliminates cyber and privacy risks

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 30 is that changes the processing medium and traceability, not the source of authority. Option A instead asserts that creates legal competence by digitisation, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Correct:** Question 30 turns on the proposition that changes the processing medium and traceability, not the source of authority. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 30 is that changes the processing medium and traceability, not the source of authority. Option C instead asserts that removes record-retention duties, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 30 is that changes the processing medium and traceability, not the source of authority. Option D instead asserts that eliminates cyber and privacy risks, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 30: Paperless is not procedure-less.

MCQ 31

Delegated legislation by a ministry must ultimately rest on A. the AoB Rules alone B. a press announcement C. authority conferred by the Constitution/statute and compliance with the parent framework D. a PMU recommendation

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 31 is that authority conferred by the Constitution/statute and compliance with the parent framework. Option A instead asserts that the AoB Rules alone, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 31 is that authority conferred by the Constitution/statute and compliance with the parent framework. Option B instead asserts that a press announcement, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Correct:** Question 31 turns on the proposition that authority conferred by the Constitution/statute and compliance with the parent framework. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.
- **D - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 31 is that authority conferred by the Constitution/statute and compliance with the parent framework. Option D instead asserts that a PMU recommendation, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.

Examiner trap 31: Administrative ownership does not equal substantive rule-making power.

MCQ 32

Article 300 is relevant here because it A. makes every PSU identical to the Union B. creates blanket sovereign immunity C. automatically establishes liability in every claim D. allows the Government of India to sue or be sued as the Union of India, while substantive liability remains separately governed

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 32 is that allows the Government of India to sue or be sued as the Union of India, while substantive liability remains separately governed. Option A instead asserts that makes every PSU identical to the Union, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **B - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 32 is that allows the Government of India to sue or be sued as the Union of India, while substantive liability remains separately governed. Option B instead asserts that creates blanket sovereign immunity, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **C - Incorrect:** The controlling proposition in Question 32 is that allows the Government of India to sue or be sued as the Union of India, while substantive liability remains separately governed. Option C instead asserts that automatically establishes liability in every claim, so it misplaces the source, function, authority or consequence tested by the stem.
- **D - Correct:** Question 32 turns on the proposition that allows the Government of India to sue or be sued as the Union of India, while substantive liability remains separately governed. This option states that proposition without enlarging its legal effect or changing the responsible institution.

Examiner trap 32: Party capacity and substantive liability are separate questions.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED DIRECT PYQ 1 - 2025 PRELIMS GS-I, SET A Q57 - OBJECTIVE

Question (official paper wording): With reference to India, consider the following pairs:

Organization	Union Ministry
I. The National Automotive Board	The Ministry of Commerce and Industry
II. The Coir Board	The Ministry of Heavy Industries
III. The National Centre for Trade Information	The Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All the three (d) None

Official answer (Set A): D.

Solution: All three displayed pairings are reversed across the relevant subject fields. The National Automotive Board belongs to the Heavy Industries field; Coir Board belongs to the MSME field; and the National Centre for Trade Information belongs to the Commerce and Industry field. Therefore none of the pairs is correctly matched.

Elimination lesson: Institution-ministry questions test the current allocation of governmental business. Infer from the parent subject or verify the dated AoB schedule; do not rely on verbal association.

Why this earns marks: It resolves every pair and uses the correct administrative-classification method.

VERIFIED SUPPORTING PYQ 2 - 2020 GS-II Q7 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS

Question: "Institutional quality is a crucial driver of economic performance". In this context suggest reforms in Civil Service for strengthening democracy.

Ownership note: The complete civil-service demand belongs primarily to Governance/Public Services; Topic 48 supplies the ministry-process dimension.

Model answer (145 words):

Institutional quality means predictable, competent and accountable exercise of public power. Civil services shape it because ministries convert elected priorities into rules, expenditure and delivery.

Reform should match competence to posts through domain tenure, continuous training and specialist teams; lateral entry should remain selective, transparent and conflict-controlled. Stable yet accountable tenure and reasoned transfer processes improve ownership. Within departments, clear Allocation of Business, delegated disposal, recorded professional advice and time-bound inter-ministerial consultation can reduce silos and delay. e-Office should preserve one authoritative record, cyber security and responsibility rather than merely digitise opacity. Parliamentary committees, audit, vigilance, grievance redress and outcome evaluation must test both legality and citizen results.

These measures should protect responsive neutrality: officials must give frank lawful advice and then implement final lawful policy without partisan capture. Civil-service reform strengthens democracy only when capability, political answerability and citizen-facing accountability advance together.

Why this earns marks: It links personnel reform to the institutional setting in which officials actually work and qualifies efficiency with democracy.

VERIFIED SUPPORTING PYQ 3 - 2024 GS-II Q3 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS

Question: "The growth of cabinet system has practically resulted in the marginalisation of the parliamentary supremacy." Elucidate.

Ownership note: This is principally owned by Parliamentary System; Topic 48 contributes ministry information, drafting, budget and delegated-legislation mechanisms.

Model answer (143 words):

India has constitutional rather than unlimited parliamentary supremacy; the proposition concerns Parliament's practical control within cabinet government.

A Cabinet commanding the Lok Sabha majority controls legislative scheduling, while ministries draft Bills, frame delegated legislation, prepare demands for grants and possess superior policy information. Party whips, limited sitting time and weak pre-legislative scrutiny can therefore reduce independent deliberation. Yet fusion also makes the executive answerable: questions, motions, no-confidence, appropriation, Department-related Standing Committees, CAG-PAC follow-up and publicity can expose departmental failure. Courts and constitutional limitations bind both Cabinet and Parliament.

The Cabinet Secretariat coordinates collective executive procedure but is not the source of legislative supremacy. Hence cabinet growth may marginalise Parliament through majority and information control, but does not extinguish its powers. Strong committees, timely departmental data, serious financial scrutiny and reasoned examination of delegated legislation can restore the balance.

Why this earns marks: It corrects the premise, explains ministry-based dominance mechanisms and supplies balanced institutional checks.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS

Question: Distinguish the Allocation of Business Rules from the Transaction of Business Rules. Why is the distinction important for accountable government?

Model answer (142 words):

Article 77(3) authorises both rule sets, but they perform different constitutional-administrative tasks.

The Allocation of Business Rules provide the jurisdictional map. Their First Schedule identifies Ministries, Departments, Secretariats and Offices; the Second distributes subjects. They answer **who owns the business** and permit notification-based reorganisation, subject to statutes.

The Transaction of Business Rules provide the decision route. Departmental business is normally disposed of by or under the Minister-in-charge, while affected departments, Finance and other mandatory authorities are consulted. Reserved classes go to Cabinet Committees, Cabinet, the Prime Minister or President through prescribed schedules.

The distinction prevents both ownerless government and unilateral government. Allocation fixes the accountable address; transaction preserves collective consultation, finance control and authorised escalation. However, neither rule set supplies substantive power contrary to a parent Act.

Thus accountable administration requires jurisdiction and procedure to converge on a recorded decision trail.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named constitutional/administrative evidence, explains the mechanism and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Better-answer check: Preserve the exact distinction, one visual spine and at least one limitation; never substitute a generic reform list.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS, 150 WORDS

Question: Explain the constitutional and administrative position of the Secretary to a Union Government department.

Model answer (148 words):

The Secretary is the department's administrative head and principal official adviser, while the Minister remains its political head and parliamentary owner.

Constitutionally, Articles 74-75 place policy responsibility in the political executive and Article 77(3) organises departmental business. Administratively, the Secretary ensures that proposals identify legal power, facts, financial implications, affected departments and viable options. The Secretary coordinates divisions, attached or subordinate offices, States and implementing bodies, while delegating routine disposal to competent levels.

The governing norm is responsive neutrality: frank, evidence-based and recorded advice before decision, followed by faithful implementation of the final lawful policy. The Secretary is not a parallel minister, but neither should anonymity conceal unlawful processing or personal misconduct. Audit, vigilance, service law, courts and file records can locate official responsibility.

Therefore secretarial leadership is best judged by lawful advice, delegated administration, coordination and institutional memory-not by the number of files escalated upward.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named constitutional/administrative evidence, explains the mechanism and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Better-answer check: Preserve the exact distinction, one visual spine and at least one limitation; never substitute a generic reform list.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS, 250 WORDS

Question: Examine the role of the Central Secretariat in policy formulation and implementation. Is the traditional policy-execution divide still useful?

Model answer (203 words):

The Central Secretariat is the collective policy, legislative, budgetary and coordination machinery of Union ministries and departments. Its comparative advantage is integrating elected priorities with law, evidence, finance and accountability.

Policy role: departments analyse problems, frame options, draft Bills and subordinate legislation, prepare expenditure proposals and consult Finance, Law, affected ministries and States. They also service Parliament, audit and courts and preserve institutional memory.

Implementation relationship: attached and subordinate offices commonly provide technical direction and field execution; autonomous bodies deliver specialised functions; CPSEs operate commercially; regulators exercise statutory mandates. This division can protect ministerial focus and operational autonomy.

Yet a rigid separation is unsafe. Implementation produces information about feasibility, exclusion and unintended effects. Mission-mode programmes and digital platforms require policy, technology, procurement and field teams to interact continuously. Excessive secretariat control causes micromanagement; excessive agency autonomy can weaken stewardship and blame mapping.

The better model is a feedback loop: the Secretariat sets lawful policy, resources and outcome expectations; implementing bodies receive delegated operational space; field evidence, audit and citizen grievances trigger redesign. One sponsoring department remains answerable, while statutory autonomy and State powers are respected.

Hence the policy-execution distinction remains analytically useful, but modern administration requires controlled integration rather than a watertight wall.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named constitutional/administrative evidence, explains the mechanism and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Better-answer check: Preserve the exact distinction, one visual spine and at least one limitation; never substitute a generic reform list.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS, 250 WORDS

Question: How does the Cabinet Secretariat secure inter-ministerial coordination? Discuss its limits.

Model answer (211 words):

The Cabinet Secretariat is the central process institution of collective Cabinet government. It functions directly under the Prime Minister, is headed administratively by the Cabinet Secretary and administers the Allocation and Transaction of Business Rules.

First, it provides secretarial assistance to Cabinet and Cabinet Committees by convening meetings, circulating agendas and papers, recording approved discussions and monitoring decisions. Second, it tackles inter-ministerial differences. Under the Transaction Rules, affected departments must be consulted; unresolved administrative issues can be placed before Committees of Secretaries, generally chaired by the Cabinet Secretary. The principal department presents its case and a dissenting department may submit a supplementary note, enabling consensus or a coordinated recommendation. Third, it assists during major crises and monitors selected cross-government initiatives.

Its limits are equally important. The Secretariat is not the Cabinet, PMO or a super-ministry. It cannot acquire a department's statutory power, override an independent regulator or replace the Minister-in-charge's parliamentary responsibility. Excessive escalation can produce apex congestion and weaken departmental initiative; weak escalation can leave silos unresolved.

Coordination should therefore follow subsidiarity: define a lead department, require timely consultation, record disagreement, resolve technical issues at official level and reserve political trade-offs for ministers or Cabinet. The Cabinet Secretariat is most effective as an enabler of responsible departments, not their substitute.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named constitutional/administrative evidence, explains the mechanism and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Better-answer check: Preserve the exact distinction, one visual spine and at least one limitation; never substitute a generic reform list.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS, 250 WORDS

Question: Critically evaluate the accountability framework governing Union ministries and departments.

Model answer (217 words):

Union ministries exercise broad policy, financial and rule-making authority; accountability must therefore connect the political owner with the internal decision trail.

Political and parliamentary control: Article 75 makes the Council collectively responsible to Lok Sabha. Questions, debates, motions, demands for grants and Department-related Standing Committees examine policy and expenditure. However, party majority, limited time and executive information advantage can blunt scrutiny.

Financial control: appropriation, departmental controls, CAG audit and PAC/Estimates/COPU examination test regularity, economy and performance. Audit is often post-facto and depends on legislative follow-up.

Legal control: courts review competence, rights, arbitrariness, reasons and procedural fairness. Parent statutes limit departmental instructions and delegated legislation. Statutory regulators retain decisional independence within their Acts.

Administrative and public control: service rules, vigilance, Lokpal/CVC jurisdictions, RTI, grievance systems, internal audit and e-Office records can identify personal and process responsibility. Article 300 permits the Government of India to sue or be sued as the Union of India, but does not itself settle every liability.

Gaps arise from fragmented schemes, opaque consultation, excessive confidentiality and shared outcomes without a lead owner. Reform should publish responsibility maps, improve committee data, record reasons and dissent, strengthen outcome evaluation and preserve a secure authoritative digital record.

Accountability is effective when political responsibility, legal review and official traceability reinforce rather than displace one another.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named constitutional/administrative evidence, explains the mechanism and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Better-answer check: Preserve the exact distinction, one visual spine and at least one limitation; never substitute a generic reform list.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS, 250 WORDS

Question: Machinery-of-government reform must balance specialisation, coordination and accountability. Analyse with reference to Secretariat reforms.

Model answer (211 words):

Machinery-of-government design decides how public purposes are grouped, staffed, coordinated and reviewed. No single structure maximises specialisation, coordination and accountability simultaneously.

Specialised departments, regulators and expert agencies improve technical competence. Selective lateral entry and multidisciplinary teams can fill capability gaps. Yet multiplication of units raises transaction costs, creates overlapping mandates and encourages blame shifting.

Central coordination through the Prime Minister, Cabinet, Cabinet Secretariat, Committees of Secretaries and mission structures can align cross-cutting outcomes. However, routine migration of files to the apex risks "court government", delay and erosion of ministerial ownership.

The Second ARC's organisational approach-rationalise functions, group related work, clarify policy and execution roles, use accountable executive agencies, simplify process and delegate-remains useful. CSMOP-style layering and e-Office can improve speed and traceability, but digitisation does not create competence or lawful authority. Mission-mode and PMU structures need a sponsoring ministry, written decision rights, budget ownership, records, conflict safeguards and sunset/mainstreaming plans.

Reform should apply a seven-part test: clear mandate; authority-funds-personnel alignment; lowest-competent-level disposal; time-bound consultation; specialist capability; parliamentary/audit/citizen accountability; and transition management for cadres, budgets, pending cases and delegated rules.

Thus the best Secretariat is neither a fragmented federation of silos nor a central command tower. It is a coordinated network with precise ownership and reconstructable responsibility.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named constitutional/administrative evidence, explains the mechanism and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Better-answer check: Preserve the exact distinction, one visual spine and at least one limitation; never substitute a generic reform list.